Sonay Kartal's Comeback Reaches the Wuhan Semifinals

From: BBC Tennis Mined: 2026-10-16 3 min read

British tennis player Sonay Kartal is having an amazing **comeback**. The 24-year-old beat Elina Svitolina of Ukraine 6-2, 2-6, 6-4 at the Wuhan Open in China. Svitolina is ranked sixth in the world.

Kartal missed more than six months of tennis because of a **stress fracture** in her back. Her **ranking** dropped to 170. But since coming back, she has won six of her eight matches. Earlier in Wuhan, she also beat Jasmine Paolini and Belinda Bencic.

The match was close. Svitolina won the second set, but Kartal won the third set to take the match. "It's breaking new ground for me this week," Kartal said. She thanked the crowd for the great **atmosphere**.

Kartal is only the second British player, after Johanna Konta, to reach this kind of big **semifinal** since 2009. On Saturday, she will play Je?ena Ostapenko, who won the French Open in 2017.

Word Treasure

comeback -- A return to success after a hard time.
stress fracture -- A small crack in a bone from too much repeated strain.
ranking -- A list that shows how good players are compared with others.
semifinal -- The round with four players left, before the final.
atmosphere -- The feeling or mood in a place.

Background you need

The Wuhan Open is a big women's tennis tournament held in China.

Tennis matches are split into sets, and in this match the first player to win two sets wins.

Players earn ranking points by winning matches, so missing many tournaments can make a ranking drop.

Break it down

WHO: British tennis player Sonay Kartal
WHAT: She beat Elina Svitolina to reach the Wuhan Open semifinals
WHERE: The Wuhan Open in China
WHY: She is playing very well after coming back from a back injury

Why it matters

Kartal shows that athletes can come back strong after getting hurt if they keep working hard.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Kartal beat at the Wuhan Open?

- (A) Johanna Konta
- (B) Je?ena Ostapenko
- (C) Belinda Bencic
- (D) Elina Svitolina

2. Why did Kartal miss more than six months of tennis?

- (A) A broken racket
- (B) A vacation
- (C) A cold
- (D) A stress fracture in her back

3. How many of her eight matches has Kartal won since coming back?

- (A) Two
- (B) Four
- (C) Eight
- (D) Six

4. Which set did Svitolina win?

- (A) The third set
- (B) The first set
- (C) The second set
- (D) None

5. Who will Kartal play on Saturday?

- (A) Elina Svitolina
- (B) Jasmine Paolini
- (C) Je?ena Ostapenko
- (D) Johanna Konta

6. In which country is the Wuhan Open?

- (A) Ukraine
- (B) Britain
- (C) France
- (D) China

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):